

RESEARCH — Producing a Feature Documentary: The Complete Craft

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US/EU industry figures from cited sources; synthesized models flagged.*

1. The stages, end to end

Financing is not a stage — it's a ladder through all stages: development money funds the teaser › teaser unlocks production money › early rough cut unlocks post money, with stops and self-funded gaps between (IDA 2025 budgeting intro). *The Silence of Others*: a 7-year funding journey; major partners came only after a great 15-min work sample. **You don't schedule a doc with one greenlight — you schedule gates, each unlocked by material (teaser › footage › rough cut).**

Durations: development 6–18 mo · production driven by the story's real-world clock · **editing ~1 month per 10 finished minutes › ~9 months for 90'** (Alliance of Documentary Editors), complex vérité "well over a year" · finishing ~12 weeks + **4 weeks deliverables** (IDA) · festival run 6–18 mo · **premiere › deal › release: "up to a year" in the current market** (IDA Sundance 2026 report) · impact campaigns need ≥18 months (Screen Daily) · **58% of doc makers report 1–5 years total** (CMSI/IDA field study). Realistic whole-project calendar for a vérité doc shot across ~1 year: **~3 years from committed development to release.** Squeezed edit schedules "drive production costs much higher" (ADE) — the edit is the longest controllable stage and the one first-timers most catastrophically underestimate.

Model calendar (synthesis): months 0–6 development in parallel with opportunistic shooting (promo = the key asset; releases from day one) · 3–15 principal production, **transcribe/organize as you go — that's edit prep, not admin** · ~10–12 **assistant editor starts, months BEFORE the editor** (organizing, transcoding, grouping, syncing transcripts) · ~12–14 **editor starts "after the majority of footage is shot but while key shooting remains"** so the edit can still redirect shooting (ADE) · 12–21 the 9-month edit (watch-down at **2 hours of screening per 1 hour of footage**, string-outs, assembly ~month 3–4, rough cut ~6–7, feedback screenings, fine cut 8–9; sales agent talks from rough cut) · 21–24 lock › 12 wks finishing + 4 wks deliverables · 24–30 premiere + run (publicist 1–2 months pre-premiere) · 26–36 sale/delivery/impact.

2. Producer vs director; the dual-hat problem

Producer = the film as a business: funded, staffed, on time, on budget, delivered "according to the legal and technical standards required by its distribution" (PGA doc code of credits; DPA guidelines). Internal budget practice: Plan A (full rates) / Plan B (realistic) / Plan C (minimum viable); contingency 6–10%; director + producer fees 5–10% each (IDA).

Dual-hat failures: (1) on-set collapse — try to produce and direct on set and you end up producing, with no director on set (The Independent Film School); add DP in safety-critical freediving conditions

and divided attention is a hazard, not an inefficiency. (2) Loss of objectivity — a separate producer gives notes from outside; the person who shot every frame is least able to kill a beautiful useless scene (Noam Kroll). (3) Financier-conflict — nobody protects the budget from the director's appetite; the standard failure is self-funding gaps + self-underpayment (IDA). (4) Burnout as schedule risk.

Delegation order as money arrives: 1) line producer/PM — the standard first hire ("hired early in pre-production... because the line producer creates and manages the budget" — Assemble/StudioBinder); rates \$5–15k/wk mid-budget, PM ~\$430/day (SetHero/Filmustage) — negotiate low-end/flat at doc scale but budget a real number. 2) assistant editor (months before editor). 3) editor. 4) production accountant/payroll (fringes vary by territory; financiers expect auditable cost reports). 5) specialists (archival producer, impact producer, publicist) at their natural stage.

3. Key roles, timing, cost anchors

- **Editor — the doc's second author, the most important hire.** ADE: "The Documentary Editor is also a writer" — no script; the editor writes every scene and the spine. Vasarhelyi (*Free Solo*): the editor is the closest collaborator, works like a writer on a narrative feature. Joe Bini: it might be 3 months before the first idea of what the story is. Hire: after majority shot, before wrap. Choose on **sensibility-match over CV** (Sam Green via Filmmaker Magazine); paid trial week on one scene. The edit is ~9 months of a senior creative — routinely the largest crew line. ADE working conditions: 8–9-hr days set by the editor, no weekends — crunch backfires.
- **Assistant editor:** starts months before the editor; "proper organization is one of the single most important factors in how quickly an editor can work" (ADE).
- **Archival producer:** as soon as archive matters — licensing takes months. Footage ~\$49–100+/sec; **TV news \$80–150/sec with 30-second minimums (\$2,400–4,500/clip)**; theatrical project minimums ~\$1,000 (Producers Library; documentarycameras.com; IDA archival guide).
- **Composer:** at fine cut; **~\$200–250 per minute of score > \$10–15k for 50 min**; commercial song licenses \$15–50k+ each (Saturation.io). Docs buy flat packages (writing + recording + stems).
- **Sound designer/re-recording mixer:** post-lock; doc post-audio ~£2–5k low end, features £4.5–13k (obodo); mix stages \$1–4k/day. A freediving film should spend ABOVE the doc norm here.
- **Colorist:** after conform; \$150–250/hr, 1–2 weeks for a feature.
- **Story consultant:** at assembly/rough-cut crises; e.g., Rough Cut Service (written dramaturgy feedback) — the cheapest editing time you'll buy.
- **Impact producer:** ~6 months pre-premiere; campaigns start at **\$15k minimum, need ~18 months** (Screen Daily; Impact Field Guide). Focused on change, not revenue.
- **Publicist/festival strategist:** 1–2 months pre-premiere; **\$5–15k per festival, \$7–12k at Sundance/TIFF-tier** incl. their travel (The Film Collaborative). Reviews at the premiere are sales collateral, not vanity.
- **Production accountant/payroll:** with first real financing.

Executive producers in docs — three species: (1) **money** — DPA tiers: financing >=50% of budget = Presentation credit + up to 4 EP credits; >=20% = "In Association with" + up to 2; >=10% = 1 EP credit (DPA crediting guidelines). (2) **Prestige/package** — a name that opens doors (sales agents

themselves now take EP/financing roles — Variety). (3) **Broadcaster/commissioning EP**. The DPA insists working credits (Producer/Co-/Associate) "may not be bought, sold, or traded." **Creative producer** shares authorship and career-long ownership; **line producer** is a hired department head who executes and moves on. **DPA waterfall rules (paper your own money!)**: deferred fees up to budgeted amounts recoup FIRST from first income, or convert to sweat equity recouping alongside investors at the same premium; each tier pro rata pari passu; **soft money you raised counts toward your share of net profits** (IDA/DPA waterfall guidelines). As financier-of-your-own-film, this is how you paper your investment so a later investor can't subordinate you.

4. Development

Treatment = the narrative document, present tense, as the film will feel; **8–15 pages standard** (DocFilmAcademy). Deck = the decision document: logline 25–40 words, synopsis, three acts, characters, visual identity, performing comparables, team, budget/finance plan, distribution strategy — tailored per audience (mission for foundations; comps/audience data for streamers). **Sizzle** (1–3 min, to 3–5 for investors) pitches the UNFINISHED film to industry; **trailer** sells the FINISHED film to audiences; teaser = shorter mood-first cousin. **Why the promo is the crown asset**: the only development artifact that proves rather than promises — access, cinematography, charisma, taste at once; it needs to persuade very few people to spend years and thousands on you (Documentary Television). **IDFA Forum takes projects at all stages EXCEPT rough cut** and wants strong visual material (IDFA) — 7 minutes in that room compresses a year of cold emails; the one-on-ones matter more than the public pitch. Vérité ≠ structureless: keep a living outline; bring the editor in early enough to flag which storylines lack coverage while you can still shoot.

5. Post-production

Workflow: AE ingest/organization (proxies, grouping, transcripts synced — before the editor starts) › watch-down at 2:1 + selects › **string-outs** (long chronological/thematic strings per character/scene) + paper edit › assembly (long, ugly, complete — 2–3× final length) › rough cut (structure works) › fine cut (scene polish, final music direction) › lock › conform, grade, sound design, **stereo + 5.1 mix, M&E** (note: Amazon and others often accept "mix minus" rather than fully-filled M&E for unscripted — check each buyer's spec), titles + **textless**, masters, captions, QC. IDA template: 12 weeks post + 4 weeks deliverables. **Feedback screenings, run deliberately**: three audiences — subject-matter experts, seasoned doc professionals, ~a dozen target-audience STRANGERS (not friends/family); slate missing GFX, label temp music; **written questionnaire completed BEFORE group discussion** (no opinion cross-contamination); someone else takes notes; weight convergent notes (New Doc Editing; Robin Piree; Frame.io). **Labs**: Sundance Doc Edit & Story Lab (assembly/rough-cut stage; travel covered; marks the film for programmers/funders) · IDFAcademy · **Ex Oriente Film** (IDF's year-long CEE program, partnered with DOK Leipzig — the natural lab for a Croatian producer) · Rough Cut Service (paid written consult) · **DAE — Documentary Association of Europe** (cheap membership, free monthly consulting, network). Labs solve the dual-hat objectivity problem with senior outside eyes at exactly the assembly/rough-cut inflection, and put the film inside the referral network programmers and funders actually use.

6. Festival › sale mechanics

Premiere status = the one-shot resource. Sundance US Doc Competition: world premieres only; ANY prior public exhibition kills eligibility. TIFF: North American premiere minimum; "public screening" = advertised/ticketed with public or press. **IDFA: world/international/European premieres; allows max TWO prior festival/market screenings; national theatrical/TV at home is permitted.** Telluride: invitation-only, secret lineup; the classic Telluride>TIFF two-step. One advertised hometown "celebration screening" can demote you everywhere. Private, unadvertised feedback screenings are fine. **Sales agents** engage at rough cut and co-design the premiere; the sales team should exist months before the festival (No Film School/Cinetic). Commissions commonly 10–15% (to 20–35% full-service international); cap recoupable expenses (\$50–75k typical caps); keep terms short (3–5 yrs where possible) — an uncapped "cheap 15%" deal still destroys producer revenue (Raindance; FilmPlatforms 2026; Wrapbook). **How buyers buy:** industry office accreditation, P&I screenings, secure screeners; triage via first-screening reception + reviews. Bidding wars are the exception and manufacturing one is high-risk (Kaufman/Distribution Advocates). **Windows:** peak 2021 (*Summer of Soul* \$15M at Sundance) › normalized (*All That Breathes*: Sundance winner, sold to HBO 4 months post-premiere; *The Perfect Neighbor* › Netflix 2025) › **Sundance 2026: zero doc deals closed at the festival; deals "take up to a year"; "no urgency"; streamers avoid politically contentious material; treat alternative distribution (Kinema, Eventive, Gathr, event/impact screenings) as Plan A** (IDA Sundance 2026 report). A spectacle-driven, apolitical, international doc with a built-in global niche community is exactly the profile that still moves.

7. First-timer mistakes that kill docs

1. **Overshooting without structure** — every extra hour costs ~2 editor-hours of screening before anything else; discipline = living outline + early editor consults on what's MISSING.
2. **Missing releases / dirty chain of title** — paper as you shoot; it all surfaces at the E&O clearance report; chasing an estranged subject's release two years later is how films die at delivery.
3. **No E&O / insurance planning** — no release without it; \$1M/\$3M, ~\$10k deductible; doc policy ~\$3–4k (3-yr), contentious content more; under-declaring budget to shave premiums backfires on claims.
4. **No post/delivery budget** — post = 20–30% of total; the fixed delivery stack (E&O, DCP \$1.5–3.5k, CC \$500–2.5k + \$800–2k/language, QC \$500–2k, legal) = **\$10–35k minimum before marketing**; films that spend to lock literally cannot accept the distribution they win.
5. **Blown premiere status** — see §6.
6. **No sales strategy until the acceptance email** — team months before premiere; publicist 1–2 months out; screeners/key art/EPK ready. "It's harder to make a good sale later."
7. **Post-money exhaustion / self-exploitation** — the documented norm is self-funded gaps + self-underpayment; put your fee and deferral terms on paper NOW per DPA waterfall rules, while you're the financier — future investors respect paper, not memory.
8. **Burnout as production risk** — ADE codified humane hours because crunch backfires; the mitigation is structural: line producer, editor's authorship protected, labs as scheduled objectivity, the 3-year calendar budgeted honestly.

Key sources

IDA 2025 budgeting intro · ADE Guide for Documentary Edit Schedules (PDF) · DPA Crediting Guidelines + Waterfall Guidelines (via IDA/documentary.org) · PGA doc code of credits · CMSI/IDA State of the Documentary Field 2018 · IDA "Don't Panic" Sundance 2026 report · Sundance 2026 Submission Rules PDF · TIFF 2026 Submissions FAQ PDF · IDFA Entry Regulations · No Film School doc sales agents (Cinetic) · Distribution Advocates "Let's Make a Deal, or Not" · Sundance sales-agent reference list · IndieWire Sundance 2025 market pieces · Variety on sales agents › financiers · Raindance / FilmPlatforms 2026 / Wrapbook on agent terms · Front Row + Kelly + Film Emporium on E&O · SetHero/Assemble/StudioBinder/Filmustage on line producers · Filmmaker Magazine + New Doc Editing + Editors Guild on editors · Producers Library + IDA archival guide on footage costs · Saturation.io + obodo + Filmustage on post costs · Thoolie + Vitrina + Amazon Studios portal on delivery · New Doc Editing + Robin Piree + Frame.io on screenings · Sundance labs + Ex Oriente/DOK Leipzig + Rough Cut Service + DAE · DocFilmAcademy (treatment/deck/sizzle) + Documentary Television + IDFA Forum + IDA pitch-forum piece · Screen Daily + Impact Field Guide on impact · The Film Collaborative on festival PR · The Independent Film School + Noam Kroll on the dual-hat problem.